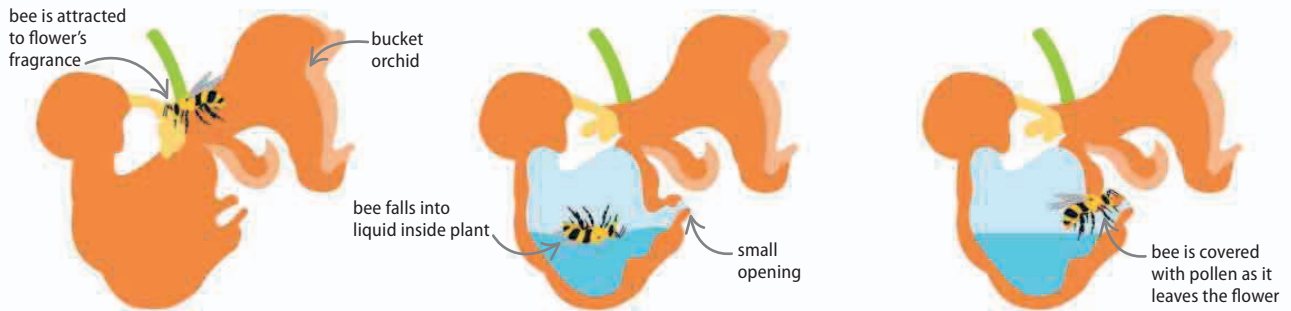


Coevolution

Sometimes, two species evolve together, adapting to ways of life by relying on each other for survival. Each organism affects the other in small ways, so the two become better adapted to each other and surviving together. Many animals and flowering plants have undergone this coevolution.

Corals have coevolved with **microscopic algae**—the algae live inside them, and provide food in return.



△ Bucket orchid and bee

This tropical flower attracts orchid bees with its fragrant oil. On landing, the bee slips on the oil and falls into a bucket, or pool, inside the petals.

△ Escape route

The bee cannot climb up the smooth walls of the bucket, but it can use a ladder of hairs that leads to a small opening on the side to escape.

△ Collecting pollen

When the bee wriggles through the exit, the flower glues sticky pollen to its back. When the bee falls into the next flower it visits, this pollen will pollinate it.

Sexual selection

Not all adaptations increase an ability to survive in competition with others. Sexual selection can produce traits that can be a hindrance, such as unwieldy antlers or long, ornate tail feathers that make flying difficult. This type of selection happens because the female chooses a particular trait in the male. The female will select the mate with the best features, and, because of this, males with that trait pass on their genes, increasing the size of the trait in the next generation.

▽ Bird tail tale

To attract a mate, a male pheasant displays its tail feathers. The females prefer long, clean feathers because they show the male is a strong specimen. Sexual selection results in larger, more ornate tail feathers. The process stops only when the tail size hinders the male and so weakens it.

